Contact

www.linkedin.com/in/chrisrhyss (LinkedIn)
www.chrisrhyss.com (Blog)
www.Soldier.ly (Company)
www.amazon.com/Good-Reasons-Chris-Rhyss-Edwards/dp/1925341313 (Other)

Top Skills

Artificial Intelligence (AI)
Human Computer Interaction
Multimodal Interaction

Honors-Awards

Anthill 100 Awards finalist 2018
Prime Minister's Veteran Entrepreneur of the Year Award finalist 2019
Zurich Insurance World Championship Bronze Medalist
Global Entrepreneur of the Year

Publications

https://www.amazon.com.au/Tougher-Than-You-Think-Resilience-ebook/dp/B0CB26ZTZK
Question: When will we be putting ‘content’ back in content marketing?
Big Data: Stop, Collaborate and Listen
Homelessness: Is a 7th Grader smarter than the PM?
The Oomph Factor: The Art of Adding Life to Your Years

Chris Rhyss Edwards (MCI)

Building Empathic AI Robots That Listen, Learn & Care | Science PhD Researcher | Sentient Interaction Design Pioneer | Veteran | TEDx XY
Brisbane City, Queensland, Australia

Summary

I build AI that doesn’t just talk—but cares. As the founder of FOLQ, a voice-first, emotionally intelligent chatbot, I’m exploring how generative AI can support mental health in a way that feels deeply human. My PhD research at Queensland University of Technology’s Digital Wellbeing Lab focuses on voice-enabled agents that listen, validate, and respond with intention—without turning us into robots. From biometric-driven tools for veterans to compassionate conversation design, my work is about building tech that feels.

Before this chapter, I was an Army Engineer turned digital innovator, leading innovative projects across companies like NewsCorp, Blockbuster, and Clemenger BBDO. I’ve written six books, including The Woke Paradox, and spoken on stages around the world about ethics, technology, and wellbeing. I’m an award-winning health-tech founder, a recovering strategist, and a perpetually curious human asking a big question: What if machines could help us be more human?

Experience

QUT (Queensland University of Technology)
Science PhD candidate
January 2025 - Present (7 months)
Brisbane, Queensland, Australia

Currently exploring the role and efficacy of adopting AI-based voice-based conversational agents (VBCAs) as an effective, affective, affordable, scalable, and accessible resource for alleviating psychological distress in healthcare workers (HCWs) through interventions delivered via active and passive mobile applications and instant messaging platforms.

Empathic Labs
Director

February 2020 - February 2025 (5 years 1 month)
Australia

Empathic Labs is a 'generativity' focused technology company. Generativity is about creating and accomplishing things that make the world a better place. It is a concern for the future, a need to contribute to the next generation by working on challenges today that will shape the lives of future generations by hacking everyday technologies in novel ways.

Soldier.ly
Founder
July 2017 - February 2020 (2 years 8 months)
Sydney, Australia

Our mission is to develop military-grade ‘empathic technologies’ to enable veterans, civilians & organisations to detect and manage stress. We developed the world's first global award winning stress detection and management smartwatch app named ID.STRESS.

Our technology tracks a range of biometric data and then alerts the wearer when their anxiety, stress or PTSD is being triggered. The partner app then provides the wearer with practical exercises and tools to reduce anxiety and stop the bodies ‘fight or flight’ response before it takes over.

Comexposium
APAC Content Director - Comexposium
October 2013 - August 2017 (3 years 11 months)
Sydney, Australia

Responsible for Comexposium APAC product (content and program strategy), spanning ideation, content production and distribution. Ensuring all content is on-brand, consistent in terms of style, quality and tone of voice, and optimized for search and UX for all channels. The goal is to ensure content quality control, drive sales, engagement, retention, and ensure a positive brand experience across all touchpoints and for attendees of Comexposium events.

QUT (Queensland University of Technology)
Master of Creative Writing Program
February 2011 - August 2012 (1 year 7 months)

Completed a full-time postgraduate Master of Creative Industries, majoring in Content Commercialization. The focus of my studies was developing a deeper skill set and knowledge base in researching, planning, writing and publishing

effective content for multiple audiences across print, screen, radio, and digital channels.

Gallery De Pasquale / Clemenger BBDO Brisbane
General Manager / Head of Digital
May 2010 - July 2011 (1 year 3 months)
Brisbane, Australia

Employed as General Manager to manage the strategic integration of the two largest independent agencies in Brisbane post-merger, whilst also engaged as Head of Digital to develop the group digital offering for the merged entity. I developed the agency strategic road map and commercialization plan, plus the content, social and search road map for key clients such as AKI, Tourism Queensland, Pizza Capers which ultimately grew agency revenues by 22% leading to acquisition offer by Clemenger.

News Digital Media
Product Director - Your Money, Business & Tech
March 2007 - March 2010 (3 years 1 month)
Sydney, Australia

Initiated and led the market and category research to identify an existing market gap to exploit for NewsCorp to launch the Your Money brand, as well as undertook category research and content planning to improve NewsCorp's mainstream Business product and to launch a mainstream Technology news products. I was responsible for scoping and defining the product brand, editorial and content strategy, as well as leading the integration of the Your Money brand across the wider business spanning print, radio and digital channels.

Derwent Howard
Head of Digital
April 2005 - January 2007 (1 year 10 months)
Sydney, Australia

Employed as Head of Digital to launch Australia's #1 niche magazine publisher’s digital product & agency offering in order to win the digital business for Blockbuster Australia. I developed the businesses digital offering, the agency strategic product roadmap and commercialization plan, launched official websites for XBOX, PlayStation and T3 brands. We also won Blockbuster's business off incumbent agency, and competitive pitches to win NRMA's Cruize project and The Rock Eisteddfod.

Sound Ideas

Content & Digital Director

July 2002 - February 2005 (2 years 8 months)

Sydney, Australia

Employed as Content Director to transform a print led product business into a ‘digital first’ content business for Sound Ideas Business Book Summaries. Developed the technology platform, a freelance contributor team, and the commercial strategy to produce book summaries for sale across digital channels at high profit.

Sensis

Online Account Manager

February 2000 - May 2002 (2 years 4 months)

Sydney, Australia

Within weeks of the global tech-wreck I commenced my digital career selling online advertising solutions - Yellow Pages online, White Pages online, Yahoo Search Listings, LookSmart listings and basic website templates - to SME's and SOHO operators across Sydney.

Australian Defence Force

Army Combat Engineer

January 1990 - July 1999 (9 years 7 months)

Australia

Trained at Army Apprentice School in Victoria and at the School of Military Engineering in Sydney to earn my qualifications as a Combat Engineer in the Australian Defence Force. I was awarded a Communications Commendation at AAS in 1991, Captained the Army team against Navy and Air Force in inter-service sport in 1992, and was part of highest ranking non-infantry team in the Army Games of 1996.

I served on the South Pacific Peacekeeping Force in Arawa in 1995 whilst posted to 3rd Combat Engineer Regiment, then received postings to 21 Construction Regiment and 20 Engineer Support Squadron in Brisbane where I decided I wanted to know what this internet thing was all about.

Education

QUT

Master of Creative Industries, Creative Writing · (2011 - 2012)

University of Adelaide

ECIC - Entrepreneuship & Innovation program, Business Administration and Management, General · (March 2006)